

# LETTERS TO A FELLOW SEEKER by STEVE CHASE

## LETTER 2

### Are Quakers Christians?

*Dear Pat,*

Thanks for writing back so quickly. I'm glad you found the story about my becoming a Quaker useful. I am also glad that you found it funny in places and inspiring in others. I particularly think your follow-up question about whether Quakers are Christians is an important one to explore.

Let me start addressing your question by offering a little historical perspective. The Quaker movement arose in the mid-1600s during the English Civil War. During that turbulent time, many people were looking to revive a "primitive Christianity" untainted by what they saw as the "imperial" distortions that had come to dominate Christendom in their day. The emerging Quaker faith and practice in this period was deeply rooted in both prophetic Judaism and the radical spiritual renewal movement led by Jesus in first century Palestine. Quakers also believed that it was now time to be directly led by the indwelling Spirit of God that had so inspired and guided Jesus during his lifetime and ministry. The early Quakers invited all people to turn to this Inward Teacher. They structured their worship so that it would be conducted as simple silent waiting on the Spirit without priests or any outward sacraments, symbols, or rituals.

At this point, the early Quaker movement was just a rag-tag band of English farmers, domestic workers, laborers, tradespeople, small business owners, and a handful of academics and a few renegades from the English nobility. They met outside in

fields, or in pubs, barns, or private homes. One thing that held these spiritual rebels together was that they, like Jesus, felt directly called by the Spirit of God to reject the dominant values of their day, which treasured power, wealth, and privilege, and to act instead to bring forth a renewed social world that was simple, just, peaceful, and sustainable.

Not surprisingly, the early Quakers were considered a significant threat to the status quo, a fact that I have long appreciated about my spiritual ancestors. I like the idea of there being lots of "dangerous Quakers" everywhere! The early Quakers were intensely persecuted by the English government and were repeatedly called heretics, heathens, and blasphemers by judges, priests, and even violent mobs. Many Quakers were jailed and some of them died from the harsh conditions in jail. Many conventional church leaders of the day denied that Quakers were Christian in any way. So, clearly, the question of whether or not Quakers are Christians has been a controversial one for centuries. The answer depends in large part on who you ask.

OK, so now let's zoom forward in time to 1968, just as I was trying to find my own answer to your important question. A few weeks after I first read that set of *Faith and Practice* queries about spiritual life, which I mentioned in my last letter, I asked one of the older Galesburg Quakers about what it meant that Quakers seemed to put their main emphasis on following Jesus rather than on believing the many specific claims about him that most people felt were essential in order to be a Christian.

This guy laughed and said that he had read the Bible several times and noticed that whenever Jesus was asked about how to live a faithful spiritual life, he never answered, "You must believe that my mother is a virgin and I am God." Instead, my new friend said, Jesus would answer all such questions with such teachings as "be loving, as God is loving." For this man, following the way of Jesus was the very essence of the Quaker movement, which he described as a spiritual community that

encourages its members to live Spirit-led lives of simplicity, integrity, equality, nonviolence, community involvement, and unity with nature. I was touched and inspired by this conversation.

My new mentor also explained to me that there are three kinds of loving talked about in the Jewish and Christian scriptures that have always been important to the Quaker movement: loving the Spirit of God with all one's heart and strength; loving our neighbors, including our enemies, as ourselves; and loving and caring for God's good earth. This, he added, is the prophetic Jewish wisdom that Jesus taught and embodied in his own life and ministry.

This is also the teaching of George Fox, one of the early English leaders of the Religious Society of Friends. As my new mentor showed me, these three forms of faithful loving were spelled out right on page two of Fox's journal. As someone raised by my dad to love wilderness and the natural world, I was particularly struck that as far back as the 1600s Quakers were talking about loving the "unity of creation" and urging people to avoid "devouring the creation" in violation of "the covenant of life." I read George Fox's words on this subject two years before the first Earth Day and I was again impressed and moved.

These conversations, and some of the vocal ministry in the meetings for worship I attended, finally inspired me to read the gospels of Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John myself, as well as the preserved letters of some of the early organizers of the spiritual movement led by Jesus. Frankly, I think it is interesting that none of these people ever used the words "Christian" or "Christianity" to describe themselves or their faith. They simply called their spiritual movement "The Way of God," or "The Way" for short.

I also have to admit that while reading the Bible for the first time in 1968, I was a bit surprised by the depth of spiritual wisdom and the intense hunger for justice that I found in the

life and ministry of Jesus. I was expecting to find the static, apolitical Jesus, concerned only about the afterlife, that I had mostly heard about in church. I could now see why Martin Luther King was so drawn to Jesus as his guide and savior, something I didn't fully understand before.

I certainly had never known, for example, that in his first public act of ministry, Jesus echoed the words of the prophet Isaiah (61:1-2) and said to the other worshipers in his synagogue:

The Spirit of the Lord is upon me,  
because he has anointed me to preach good news to the poor.  
He has sent me to proclaim release to the captives  
and recovering of sight to the blind,  
to set at liberty those who are oppressed,  
to proclaim the acceptable year of the Lord.

While reading this, I experienced these words as if someone stood up in the silence of a meeting for worship and gave inspired vocal ministry that went straight to my heart. I came to love Jesus intensely, and through him I felt closer to the Spirit that he had turned to so powerfully for divine presence, love, and guidance.

Later on, I also read the prophets in the Hebrew scriptures and found several spiritual ancestors there as well. I especially loved the Jewish feminine imagery of Sophia to signify the Inward Teacher, the spirit of divine wisdom that is accessible to all, something that Quaker theologian Robert Barclay also pointed to in 1692. I found it both strange and exhilarating to feel so connected to a living, pulsing spiritual tradition with ancient roots that spoke so powerfully to me across time. I was both comforted and challenged when I finally learned about Jesus and the prophets by reading the Bible myself, not just hearing about them from others.

As I kept going to meetings for worship, reading more, and walking with the Galesburg Quakers and then with the Quakers

from DeKalb, Illinois, where I moved two years later, I increasingly felt that I was also kin with the earliest Quakers. They became my closest spiritual ancestors. Here was a radical spiritual renewal movement that embraced the nonviolent revolutionary path of Jesus. Three hundred years before me, these people had offered a liberating alternative to the idolatry and worship of dogma, wealth, hierarchy, war, and empire, which had come to dominate all the kingdoms in Europe as well as their state-sponsored churches. When I looked around me at the world I lived in during the late 1960s, filled with materialism and militarism at home and abroad, it still seemed to me that "primitive Christianity" needed to be revived and practiced in our world and in my own heart.

I could now answer all the *Faith and Practice* queries about spiritual life in the affirmative. Yes, I seek to live in thankful awareness of God's constant presence. Yes, I seek to be sensitive and obedient to leadings of the Holy Spirit. Yes, I seek to be a friend and follower of Jesus. And, yes, I seek to nurture my spiritual life with prayer, silent waiting worship, and regular study of the Bible and other spiritual literature. Taken together, this is a core part of what the Quaker way means to me.

But does this make me a Christian in today's world? Personally, I usually answer yes when asked, but it all depends on how people define the word. For example, back when I was fifteen and had been a practicing Quaker for about two years, I once fell into a conversation with an elderly street evangelist on the main street of DeKalb. He started our conversation by walking up to me, handing me a brochure, and asking, "Are you a Christian?"

As a teenage Quaker inspired by the Spirit of God and the prophetic ministry and life example of Jesus, I quickly answered yes. Yet, this man was not convinced at all and began asking many questions about my religious beliefs. After just a few minutes, he informed me that I was not a "true" Christian, even though I professed to be. As he explained it, I simply did

not fit any meaningful definition of a Christian because my personal interpretations of God, Jesus, and the Bible were all wrong. In fact, he said I was worse off than someone who had never heard of Jesus Christ. I was a heretic.

For a brief moment, I tensed up, remembering how early Quakers were regularly condemned, beaten, and imprisoned on charges of heresy by the "orthodox" Christian authorities of their day. Yet, this situation was very different. The sincere gentleman in front of me was not an authority, nor did he wish to imprison me or harm me in any way. He simply wanted to convince me of the error of my ways. I could respect that.

No longer feeling threatened, I relaxed and became interested in the man's religious beliefs. I asked him what he thought it would take for me to become a "true" Christian. He replied that at a minimum a real Christian ascribes to particular articles of faith, for example, that Jesus is the only begotten son of God, that he is part of a three-person Godhead, that he sacrificed himself for the atonement of our sins, and that he rose bodily from the grave three days after his execution and will come again on a final Judgment Day. The evangelist also told me that all "non-believers," no matter how morally exemplary their lives, would be barred from heaven and would suffer eternal damnation in hell after their deaths.

I could now see why he did not think I was a Christian. This was not how I understood my own faith and practice at all. Certainly, the people in my Quaker meeting did not think that these intellectual notions about Jesus were essential for people to live in harmony with the Spirit, our neighbors, and the wider world of life. This was even true of those Quakers who did accept some of these beliefs, as some Quakers do.

While I don't know about you, as a fifteen-year-old Quaker back in 1970, I was far more concerned with living faithfully in the here and now than in worrying about a possible next life. I was also far less interested in people's theological beliefs about

Jesus than in our collectively figuring out how to follow Jesus's way of living in our own lives and times—to love God with all one's heart, strength, and soul; to love and care for one's neighbors as one's self; and to love God's good earth and all other forms of life. If people could help each other follow Jesus's transforming, Spirit-led way of life, regardless of their different theological beliefs about his status in the grand scheme of things, I was convinced that deep spiritual renewal was possible in our world.

I soon discovered that my new acquaintance had another standard for sorting out who was a "true" Christian from all those who professed to be. He said that for me to become a real Christian, I would also need to believe that every passage of the Bible is historically and factually accurate, as well as a complete, infallible revelation of God's will in all moral and doctrinal matters. As my yearly meeting's *Faith and Practice* notes, "Compiled from the inspiration of many ancient writers, the Bible has been for Friends not a blueprint or final authority, but a source of knowledge of God's ways with us." Viewing the Bible as a beloved and special source of spiritual wisdom and moral guidance was clearly not enough for my new street evangelist acquaintance.

He and I did agree about one thing, though. We both felt that the Spirit of God seeks out those of us who are lost in order to save us. Yet, even here, we soon found that we had very different views about what the word salvation means. For him, it seemed to mean an eternal afterlife in paradise if you accepted some very specific beliefs about God, Jesus, and the Bible. The Quakers I knew had a very different understanding of salvation. As Samuel Caldwell, the former general secretary of Philadelphia Yearly Meeting, beautifully says about the Quaker view of salvation:

Historically, it is this: God gives to every human being who comes into the world a measure of the Spirit through which

divine guidance is inwardly received and the conscience enlightened. Every human being has direct access through this "inner Light" to divine inspiration for guidance for living in accordance with God's will. Those who discern and heed the promptings of this Inner Light in their daily lives are "saved"—that is, they come into fullness and wholeness of life and right relationship with God and one another. Those who resist, ignore, or disobey this Inner Light, even if they profess religion, are "damned"—that is, doomed to unhappiness and alienation from God, from themselves, and from one another.

I finally told the man that while I appreciated his strong convictions, I could not share them. Nor could I agree with his definition of a "true" Christian. I told him that I agreed instead with William Penn when he said, "To be like Christ then, is to be a Christian." I walked away not wanting to upset this man, but neither was I willing to abandon all of Christianity to him. The Quaker movement has long been a profound affirmation of following the mystical and prophetic faith and practice of Jesus of Nazareth and the spiritual renewal movement he led in first century Palestine. The challenge for us is in finding meaningful ways to understand and express this spiritual path in our contemporary world.

Now some easily identify this approach as Christian, as I do. Modern Quaker writer Phillip Gully also sees Quaker faith and practice as Christian, at least at its best. In his book *If the Church Were Christian: Rediscovering the Values of Jesus*, his chapter themes describe the core elements that he believes make a spiritual community a Christian community. For such communities:

- Jesus is a model for living rather than an object of worship;
- Affirming our potential is more important than condemning our brokenness;
- Reconciliation is valued over judgment;
- Gracious behavior is more important than right belief;

- Inviting questions is valued more than supplying answers;
- Encouraging personal exploration is more important than communal uniformity;
- Meeting human needs is more important than maintaining institutions;
- Peace is more important than power;
- Love is more important than sex; and
- Life is more important than the afterlife.

If this is how you also understand Christianity, then I think it is quite fair to call Quakers Christian.

At the same time, it is also important to know that Quakers have long been interfaith "universalists," as well as Christians. For example, here is a beautiful statement from colonial American Quaker John Woolman. I love its expansive and inclusive vision of faithfulness and salvation.

There is a principle that is pure, placed in the human mind, which in different places and ages has had different names. It is, however, pure and proceeds from God. It is deep and inward, confined to no forms of religion nor excluded from any, where the heart stands in perfect sincerity. In whomsoever this takes root and grows, of what nation soever they become brethren in the best sense of the expression.

This is a remarkably radical way to understand the essence of the Quaker faith, and it raises the possibility of deep spiritual community and faithful unity reaching across the boundaries of nationalities, cultures, and even historic faith traditions. Even to the degree that you and I may both agree that Quakers are Christian, we are not exclusively so. Quakers believe that everyone who sincerely follows the Inward Teacher, regardless of their religion or culture, should be considered our spiritual brothers and sisters.

Today, our Quaker meetings often reflect this universalist value by the religious diversity of our communities. Some contemporary Quakers identify themselves as Jewish Quakers, Sufi Quakers, Buddhist Quakers, Hindu Quakers, Pagan Quakers, and a variety of other hybrid religious identities. This interesting mix of faithful unity and theological diversity is certainly the case at my own meeting. Yet, at its best, the non-Christian Quakers in our meetings draw from these other faith traditions qualities that are spiritually enlightening and fully consistent with following the way of Jesus and with the longstanding spiritual path of the Quaker movement. Gandhi, for example, was a far more faithful friend and follower of Jesus than many Christians, and he was Hindu. I would happily worship with him!

So here are my questions to you. Does this inclusive and somewhat fuzzy approach of the contemporary Quaker movement sound a little crazy to you? Or, do you see value in the Quaker movement today being a simple, radical, and contemporary faith tradition rooted in the best of Judaism and Christianity, open to new Light, and very appreciative of the complementary truths and practices that are found in many other spiritual traditions around the world? I truly won't be offended either way you answer. I'm just interested.

I have a cousin who lives in Arkansas and is a Southern Baptist. Like me, she also does her best to be loving and faithful in following the way of Jesus. We are both Jesus-inspired, Bible-reading, and Spirit-led Christians. Yet, she holds a more orthodox theology than I do about Jesus and thinks the Quaker movement is a little "crackers" because of our looser theological boundaries about who is welcomed into our communities and our meetings for worship. She loves me, sees my spiritual sincerity, but she does not see my version of Christianity as sufficient for eternal salvation.

My Quaker meeting would not feel like a good spiritual home for my cousin. She would feel uncomfortable worship-

ping regularly in a religious congregation where not everyone believed that Jesus is "the only begotten Son of God," or shared other "orthodox" beliefs that are very important to her.

If you agree with my cousin, I would be happy to provide some information about another stream of the Quaker movement that includes formally appointed pastors, planned worship services, and a greater reliance on orthodox Protestant Christian beliefs in their religious life. This stream of the Quaker movement, which began in the United States, has grown considerably since the nineteenth century. It has organized over a dozen yearly meetings in North America, has set up overseas missions, and has developed national and international networks, including Friends United Meeting and Evangelical Friends Church International. The majority of Quakers in Palestine, Kenya, Cuba, and several South American countries are part of this branch of the movement.

Quakers from what we call the "pastoral" or "programmed" tradition are dear spiritual siblings, and I have great respect for their version of Quaker faith and practice. I am delighted that they are also strong supporters of the historic and evolving Quaker testimonies on peace, equality, integrity, simplicity, civic engagement, and unity with nature.

Just last Saturday I co-led a workshop at Durham Friends Meeting, one of the few pastoral Quaker congregations in my area. Their pastor kindly asked me to stay over to worship with them on Sunday morning and to give the main message as a guest minister. We started the morning with silence while sitting in pews all facing the front of the room, sang hymns requested by people in the congregation, listened to a prepared Bible reading, sank back into silence, and then I stood and spoke for a quarter of an hour at the pulpit, giving the prepared sermon. We then entered into open silent worship again, during which different people spontaneously gave ministry from the congregation. It was a somewhat new and different

form of Quaker worship for me, a variation on a theme, yet was as deep as the worship that I was used to.

If you would like, I could send you more information about these pastoral Quaker meetings. Personally, though, I am still much more powerfully drawn to "my" wing of the modern Quaker movement, in which there is no pastor, we sit facing each other, we gather and remain in deep silent worship for much longer periods of time, and it is much more common to include "non-Christian" Quakers, unorthodox followers of Jesus like myself, as well as more traditional "Christ-Centered" Quakers, all in one worshipping community.

To me, as long as we are seeking to follow in the way of Jesus and are open to the guidance of the Inward Teacher, regardless of what words or traditions most excite our minds, I feel we will have sufficient unity to be a vibrant, world-changing, spiritual community in the challenging times ahead. What do you think?

*Affectionately,*

Steve

## LETTER 3

# Silent Worship and the Inward Teacher

*Dear Pat,*

Thank you for your last letter. I am pleased that you resonate with the idea that a group of people can find deep spiritual unity and wisdom, even if they don't always hold identical beliefs about what you called "the big cosmological status of Jesus." This is done among "my" stream of the Quakers, just as you say, by turning toward the Inward Teacher together in silent waiting worship and opening ourselves to the direct experience of divine love and guidance as a group.

For me, silent Quaker worship is one of the loveliest wildflowers in the garden of the world's spiritual practices. It sounds like you are interested in learning more about it. I will try to answer your questions as best as I can. Yet, I encourage you to experiment with Quaker worship firsthand and attend some Quaker meetings for worship in your area. Direct experience is almost always preferable to words on a page—as helpful as words can be. If you are interested in doing this, you can find the Quaker meetings in your local area by going to the Quaker Finder website at [www.quakerfinder.org](http://www.quakerfinder.org).

Also, before I try to explain what I can about Quaker worship, I have to offer a big disclaimer here: "results may vary when using this product!" I'm only half kidding. For example, both the early Quaker theologian Robert Barclay and I had very deep spiritual experiences the very first time we visited a